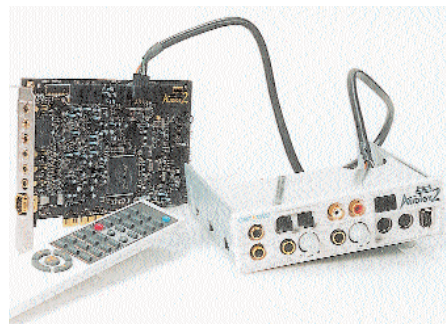


Creative SoundBlaster Audigy2 Platinum

Listen easy

The Audigy2 Platinum is a culmination of all of Creative's former technologies and more. Apart from the universal Line In and Line Out outputs and Microphone input, the Audigy2 also incorporates a 5.1-compatible



S/PDIF mini-jack output and an SB1394 port. The SB1394 port opens up a host of possible applications and opportunities, especially if your board does not support FireWire. In addition, the option of using coaxial or optical S/PDIF, and internal connectors for the CD In inputs are also provided. It also has a 15-pin MIDI/game port on the internal bracket. There are two Line In inputs with gain control, for connecting devices such as your electric guitar. As with Sound Blaster Audigy, the Audigy2 supports time-scaling, which makes it easier to pick up guitar solos. The infrared port enables remote controlling for additional convenience.

On the features side, the Audigy2 has a 106 dB Signal to Noise Ratio (SNR), which means there are almost no distortions, even at high volumes. It supports DVD Audio playback and the 24-bit 192 or 96 KHz linear PCM sounds much sharper than CD Audio. The Dolby Digital EX 6.1 decoding gives a great surround effect, with the addi-

tion of a rear centre channel for precise surround sound. The 32-bit effects engine with real-time effects, mixing and 3D positioning capabilities is a real boon for hardcore gamers. It supports Direct Sound 3D, EAX 1.0, 2.0 and EAX Advanced HD. Apart from this it also has 64 hardware managed polyphonic voices and is compatible with Windows Media Audio 9. Sound recording can be done at 8, 16 or 24 bits at a frequency of

96 KHz. The card also has two 16-channel MIDI hardware synthesizers. But that's not all. The package comes with over 4 GB of fun programs, including games such as *Soldier of Fortune II: Double Helix*, *Hitman 2: Silent Assassin* and programs such as Traktor DJ, Ulead 5, Video studio, a DVD sampler CD, demo CD and the installation CD.

Some other programs included in the package are Creative Media Source, Audio Stream Recorder 2, Creative Diagnostic, Mini Disc Centre, Creative Wave Studio, Speaker Calibrator, SoundFont Bank Manager, Surround Sound Mixer, Speaker Settings and Steinberg Cubasis VST. And let's not forget the inclusion of a user-friendly quickstart guide.

The main improvements in the Audigy2 are in the form of sound quality—both in recording and playback—and the 6.1 channel support for movies and games. It also features THX multimedia certification, guaranteeing crystal-clear audio.

The Audigy2 Platinum is

certainly aimed at making an impact on the world of the music editing enthusiast and hardcore gamer. At Rs 15,899, though, it's on the list of only those select few who demand nothing but the best.

Price: Rs 15,899
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Labtec Pulse 420 2.1-channel speakers

On a jarring note

The Pulse 420 scores well in the looks department and the satellites are cute to look at. The speaker system is very easy to set up, due to the colouring system. The satellites are designed well, and they can either be placed on the desk or hung on a nail without any additional fittings to the speaker. The wires are approximately 8 feet long and the connections go to the subwoofer, placed under the desk. The satellite, input and DC connections all go into the subwoofer. The headphone jack and volume controls are placed on the right satellite.

The speakers displayed an inconsistent performance, performing well in some tests and below par in some others. The speakers sounded loud and clear when Audio CDs and MP3 files were played and they also passed the frequency tests with ease. The

SPECIFICATIONS
DVD-Audio capability (24-bit with 192 KHz in stereo and 96 KHz in 5.1), 106 dB Signal to Noise Ratio, 6.1 surround sound capability, EAX Advanced HD support, WMA 9 support, FireWire port

Creative SoundBlaster Audigy2 Platinum		B+
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶	



main problem area was the bass and subwoofer tests. Because of the light weight of the woofers, at high volumes, the whole subwoofer vibrates rather alarmingly and slowly moves across the floor.

Another flaw is the absence of a detailed manual and a troubleshooting guide. But the final nail in the speaker's coffin is its price. At Rs 3,450, it is nearly equal to a low-end 4.1 set. This could have been overlooked if the speakers were excellent and provided amazing levels of sound. However, in the current market scenario, where low-end 2.1 speaker sets start from Rs 1,000, the Pulse 420's pricing is difficult to justify.

SPECIFICATIONS
Two satellites with subwoofer, five watts RMS per satellite, 15 watts RMS for subwoofer, 40 Hz to 20 KHz frequency response

Labtec Pulse 420		C+
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶	

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